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Bachelor Thesis
Parallel ASP Planning

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Ich versichere, dass ich diese Bachelor-Arbeit selbstständig verfasst und nur die angegebenen Quellen und Hilfsmittel verwendet habe.

Heidelberg, dd.mm.yyyy

Zusammenfassung

Dies ist eine Zusammenfassung der Arbeit.

Abstract

This is the abstract.

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1 Introduction

This chapter contains an overview of the topic as well as the goals and contributions of your work.

1.1 Motivation

1.2 Goal of the Thesis

1.3 Structure of the Thesis

Here you describe the structure of the thesis. For example:

In Kapitel [2](#) werden grundlegende Methoden für diese Arbeit vorgestellt.

2 Theory

2.1 Definition

Definition 1 *Multi-valued planning task*. A STRIPS-like multivalued planning task according to (Helmert 2006) is given by a 4 tuple $\langle \mathcal{F}, s_0, s_*, \mathcal{O} \rangle$, where:

- $\mathcal{F}$ is a finite set of state variables, also called **fluents**. Each $x \in \mathcal{F}$ has a finite domain and in every state, x takes exactly one value from its domain.
- s_0 , the **initial state**, is a total function, s.t. $s_0(x) \in \text{dom}(x)$ for each $x \in \mathcal{F}$, i.e. a function that maps each fluent to a value from its domain.
- s_* , the **goal conditions**, is a partial function, s.t. $s_*(x) \in \text{dom}(x)$, for each $x \in \text{dom}(s_*)$ i.e. a function that specifies the desired values for a subset of fluents.
- $\mathcal{O}$ is a finite set of operators, also called **actions**. We define an action a as $\langle a^c, a^e \rangle$, where a^c is the precondition and a^e is the postcondition of a . Both a^c and a^e are partial functions, s.t. $a^c(x) \in \text{dom}(x)$ for each $x \in \text{dom}(a^c)$ and $a^e(x) \in \text{dom}(x)$ for each $x \in \text{dom}(a^e)$.

Remark. An action a also has a finite set of effects eff , where $\text{eff} = \langle \text{cond}, x, v \rangle$. cond , the effect condition, is a (possibly empty) partial function, s.t. $\text{cond}(x) \in \text{dom}(x)$ for each $x \in \text{dom}(\text{cond})$. $x \in \mathcal{F}$ is the effected fluent and $v \in \text{dom}(x)$ is the value assigned to x if cond holds.

Example 1. Let us illustrate the definitions with a small example. The plan is to leave the house by opening the door, going outside, and finally closing the door.

- $\mathcal{F} = \{\text{door}, \text{location}\}$ with $\text{dom}(\text{door}) = \{\text{open}, \text{closed}\}$, $\text{dom}(\text{location}) = \{\text{inside}, \text{outside}\}$
- Initial state: $s_0 = \{\text{door}=\text{closed}, \text{location}=\text{inside}\}$
- Goal: $s_* = \{\text{door}=\text{closed}, \text{location}=\text{outside}\}$
- Actions: $\mathcal{O} = \{\text{openDoor}, \text{closeDoor}, \text{goOut}\}$, where

$$\begin{aligned} \text{openDoor} &= \langle \{\text{door}=\text{closed}\}, \{\text{door}=\text{open}\} \rangle \\ \text{closeDoor} &= \langle \{\text{door}=\text{open}\}, \{\text{door}=\text{closed}\} \rangle \\ \text{goOut} &= \langle \{\text{location}=\text{inside}, \text{door}=\text{open}\}, \{\text{location}=\text{outside}\} \rangle \end{aligned}$$

Definition 2 *Successor state*. Let s be state and $a \in \mathcal{O}$ an action.

The *successor state* $o(a, s)$, obtained by applying action a in state s , is defined if the precondition

of a holds, i.e., $a^c(x) = s(x)$ for all $x \in \text{dom}(a^c)$. Then

$$s'(x) = o(a, s) = \begin{cases} a^e(x) & \text{if } x \in \text{dom}(a^e) \\ s(x) & \text{otherwise.} \end{cases}$$

Remark. Let $A_n = \langle a_1, \dots, a_n \rangle$ be a sequence of actions with length n . We define the application of A_n to a state s recursively by

$$o(A_n, s) = o(a_n, o(A_{n-1}, s))$$

if $o(A_i, s)$ is defined for all $1 \leq i \leq n$.

Definition 3 Sequential plan. A sequential plan is a sequence of actions $A_n = \langle a_1, \dots, a_n \rangle$, s.t. $s' = o(A_n, s_0)$ is defined and $s'(x) = s_*(x)$ for all $x \in \text{dom}(s_*)$.

Example 2. Consider the planning task from the previous example. One possible sequential plan is $A = \langle \text{openDoor}, \text{goOut}, \text{closeDoor} \rangle$. Since

$$\begin{aligned} o(A, s_0) &= o(\langle \text{openDoor}, \text{goOut}, \text{closeDoor} \rangle, \{\text{door}=\text{closed}, \text{location}=\text{inside}\}) \\ &= o(\langle \text{goOut}, \text{closeDoor} \rangle, \{\text{door}=\text{open}, \text{location}=\text{inside}\}) \\ &= o(\text{closeDoor}, \{\text{door}=\text{open}, \text{location}=\text{outside}\}) \\ &= \{\text{door}=\text{closed}, \text{location}=\text{outside}\} = s_* \end{aligned}$$

For parallel actions and plans, we first need the definition of a confluent set of actions.

Definition 4 confluent. Let $A = \{a_1, \dots, a_n\} \subseteq \mathcal{O}$ be a set of actions.

A is *confluent* : $\iff a_i^e(x) = a_j^e(x)$ for all $1 \leq i < j \leq n$ and each $x \in \text{dom}(a_i^e) \cap \text{dom}(a_j^e)$

Remark. A is confluent $\iff B$ is confluent for all $B \subseteq A$

Example 3. In our example $\{\text{openDoor}, \text{goOut}\}$ and $\{\text{closeDoor}, \text{goOut}\}$ are confluent sets. We extend the example with the fluents *light* and *key* where $\text{dom}(\text{light}) = \text{dom}(\text{key}) = \{0, 1\}$ and two actions *lightsOut* and *getKey*:

$$\begin{aligned} \text{lightsOut} &= \langle \{\text{location}=\text{inside}, \text{light}=1\}, \{\text{light}=0\} \rangle \\ \text{getKey} &= \langle \{\text{location}=\text{inside}, \text{key}=0\}, \{\text{key}=1\} \rangle \end{aligned}$$

Additionally, we modify the precondition: $\text{openDoor}^c = \{\text{door}=\text{closed}, \text{key}=1\}$ and our new goal is $s_* = \{\text{location}=\text{outside}, \text{door}=\text{closed}, \text{light}=0\}$.

Now for example $\{\text{getKey}, \text{openDoor}, \text{goOut}, \text{lightsOut}\}$ and $\{\text{getKey}, \text{closeDoor}, \text{goOut}, \text{lightsOut}\}$ are also confluent sets of actions.

Definition 5 *Parallel representations*. Let s be a state and $A = \{a_1, \dots, a_n\}$ be a confluent set of actions. Then A is

- (i) $\forall$ -step serializable in $s : \iff o(\langle a_{\pi(1)}, \dots, a_{\pi(n)} \rangle, s)$ is defined for all permutations π
- (ii) $\exists$ -step serializable in $s : \iff o(\langle a_{\pi(1)}, \dots, a_{\pi(n)} \rangle, s)$ is defined for some permutation π
and $a^c(x) = s(x)$ for each $a \in A$ and $x \in \text{dom}(a^c)$
- (iii) relaxed $\exists$ -step serializable in $s : \iff o(\langle a_{\pi(1)}, \dots, a_{\pi(n)} \rangle, s)$ is defined for some permutation π

Remark. A is $\forall$ -step serializable $\Rightarrow A$ is $\exists$ -step serializable $\Rightarrow A$ is relaxed $\exists$ -step serializable.

Definition 6 *Parallel Plans*. Let $A = \langle A_1, \dots, A_n \rangle$ be a sequence of confluent sets of actions. A is a $\forall$ -step, $\exists$ -step or relaxed $\exists$ -step plan iff

- $s_n(x) = s_*(x)$ for each $x \in \text{dom}(s_*)$
- A_i is $\forall$ -step, $\exists$ -step or relaxed $\exists$ -step serializable in s_{i-1} for $1 \leq i \leq n$, where
$$s_i(x) = \begin{cases} a^e(x) & \text{if } x \in \text{dom}(a^e) \\ s_{i-1}(x) & \text{else} \end{cases} \quad \text{for each } a \in A_i$$

Example 4. In our modified example we have:

- $\forall$ -step plan: $\langle \{getKey, lightsOut\}, \{openDoor\}, \{goOut\}, \{closeDoor\} \rangle$
- $\exists$ -step plan: $\langle \{getKey, lightsOut\}, \{openDoor\}, \{goOut, closeDoor\} \rangle$
- relaxed $\exists$ -step plan: $\langle \{getKey, lightsOut, openDoor, goOut\}, \{closeDoor\} \rangle$

2.2 ASP

In ASP, planning tasks are represented by facts. A solution of an ASP encoding is called *stable model*.

```

1  fluent(door; loc; light; key).
2  value(door, 0).  value(door, 1).
3  value(loc, in).  value(loc, out).
4  value(light, 0).  value(light, 1).
5  value(key, 0).  value(key, 1).
6
7  init(door, 0).  init(loc, in).  init(light, 1).  init(key, 0).
8  goal(door, 0).  goal(loc, out).  goal(light, 0).
9
10 action(openDoor; closeDoor; goOut; lightOut; getKey).
11 prec(openDoor, door, 0).  prec(openDoor, key, 1).  post(openDoor, door, 1).
12 prec(closeDoor, door, 1).  post(closeDoor, door, 0).
13 prec(goOut, loc, in).  prec(goOut, door, 1).  post(goOut, loc, out).
14 prec(lightOut, loc, in).  prec(lightOut, light, 1).  post(lightOut, light, 0).
15 prec(getKey, loc, in).  prec(getKey, key, 0).  post(getKey, key, 1).

```

Listing 1: ASP encoding of the example planning task

Combining these facts with the right encodings, stable models correspond to the *sequential*, $\forall$ -step, $\exists$ -step or *relaxed $\exists$ -step plans*.

```

1  #include <incmode>.
2  holds(X, V, 0) :- init(X, V).
3  #program check(t).
4  :- query(t), goal(X, V), not holds(X, V, t).
5  #program step(t).
6  {holds(X, V, t) : value(X, V)} = 1 :- fluent(X).
7  {occurs(A, t)} :- action(A).
8  :- occurs(A, t), post(A, X, V), not holds(X, V, t).
9  :- holds(X, V, t), not holds(X, V, t-1), not occurs(A, t) : post(A, X, V).

```

Listing 2: Core for sequential and parallel encodings for planning

All planning algorithms share a common incremental encoding using the incmode for clingo as seen in Listing 2 (Gebser et al. 2014). The program is divided into three subprograms: *base*, *step(t)* and *check(t)*.

The *base* subprogram contains the static part of the encoding, which is only grounded once. Line 2 defines the initial state s_0 , where the predicate $holds(X, V, t)$ is used to represent fluents $X \in \mathcal{F}$ that have value $V \in dom(X)$ at timestep t .

$check(t)$ is a parametrized subprogram starting at $t = 0$. The integrity constraint in Line 4 checks if $s_*(X) = s_t(X) \forall X \in dom(s_*)$. $Query(t)$ is true only for the latest integer t .

$step(t)$ is grounded after check fails for each timestep t starting at $t = 1$. Note that postconditions of applied actions in timestep t are also set in t and the preconditions have to hold in $t - 1$. Lines 6 defines holds for times step t , giving fluent X one value V from its domain and $occurs(A, t)$ in Line 7 are all possible actions in timestep t obeying rules 8 and 9. Line 8 ensures that the postcondition of an action is applied and also assert the confluence of any set of action applied in parallel since if $V = a^e(X) \neq \tilde{a}(X) = \tilde{V}$ either $holds(X, V, t)$ or $holds(X, \tilde{V}, t)$ would be false. Line 9 makes sure that fluents not affected by any action keep their value from the previous timestep. So far, the common core handles the transitions from one state to the next in regards of the postcondition of applied actions.

2.2.1 encoding for sequential plans

```

1 :- occurs(A, t), prec(A, X, V), not holds(X, V, t-1).
2 :- #count{A : occurs(A, t)} > 1.

```

Listing 3: Extension for sequential plans

Starting with the extension for sequential plans as seen in Listing 3, Line 2 ensures that the precondition of an applied action is met in $t - 1$ and Line 3 only allows one action to occur per timestep.

Example 5. Running this with our example, we get three possible sequential plans.

```

Answer: 1
occurs(getKey,1) occurs(lightOut,2) occurs(openDoor,3) occurs(goOut,4) occurs(closeDoor,5)
Answer: 2
occurs(getKey,1) occurs(openDoor,2) occurs(lightOut,3) occurs(goOut,4) occurs(closeDoor,5)
Answer: 3
occurs(lightOut,1) occurs(getKey,2) occurs(openDoor,3) occurs(goOut,4) occurs(closeDoor,5)

```

Listing 4: Output from clingo for sequential encoding

2.2.2 encoding for $\forall$ -step plans

```

1 :- occurs(A, t), prec(A, X, V), not holds(X, V, t-1).
2 :- occurs(A, t), prec(A, X, V), not post(A, X, _), not holds(X, V, t).
3 single(X, t) :- occurs(A, t), prec(A, X, V1), post(A, X, V2), V1 != V2.
4 :- single(X, t), #count{A : occurs(A, t), post(A, X, V)} > 1.

```

Listing 5: Extension for $\forall$ -step plans

Now for the extension for $\forall$ -step plans as seen in Listing 5, Line 1 is the same as in the sequential encoding. As mentioned before, the integrity constraint in Line 8 of the common core already ensures confluence of applied actions. Since the sequence of the actions has to be valid for all permutations, we have to make sure that no action invalidates the precondition of any other action. Let a be an action applied in parallel and $X \in \text{dom}(a^c)$. There are two cases to consider:

1. the fluent X remains unchanged, i.e. $X \in \text{dom}(a^c) \cap \text{dom}(a^e)$ and $a^c(X) = a^e(X)$ or $X \in \text{dom}(a^c)$ and $X \notin \text{dom}(a^e)$
2. the postcondition of a invalidates its precondition, i.e. $X \in \text{dom}(a^e) \cap a^c(X) \neq a^e(X)$ for an action a

Line 2 handles the first case, while the second case is a little trickier. If there is such an action, there can not be another action $\tilde{a}$ with $X \in \text{dom}(\tilde{a}^e)$, since if $a^e(X) = \tilde{a}^e(X)$, the precondition of a is invalidated and if $a^e(X) \neq \tilde{a}^e(X)$, the confluence is undermined. For this, we define these actions described in (ii) as $\text{single}(X, t)$ in Line 3 and the integrity constraint in Line 4 ensures that there is at most one such action for each fluent X in timestep t .

Example 6. Running this with our example, we get two possible $\forall$ -step plans.

```

Answer: 1
occurs(getKey,1) occurs(openDoor,2) occurs(lightOut,2) occurs(goOut,3) occurs(closeDoor,4)
Answer: 2
occurs(lightOut,1) occurs(getKey,1) occurs(openDoor,2) occurs(goOut,3) occurs(closeDoor,4)

```

Listing 6: Output from clingo for $\forall$ -step encoding

2.2.3 encoding for $\exists$ -step plans

```
1 :- occurs(A, t) , prec(A, X, V), not holds(X, V ,t -1).
2 apply(A1, t) :- action(A1),
3     ready(A2, t) : post(A1, X, V1), prec(A2, X, V2), A1 != A2, V1 != V2.
4 ready(A, t) :- action(A), not occurs(A, t).
5 ready(A, t) :- apply(A, t).
6 :- action(A) , not ready(A, t).
```

Listing 7: Extension for $\exists$ -step plans

```
1 :- occurs(A, t), prec(A ,X ,V), not holds(X, V, t-1).
2 #edge((A1, t), (A2, t)): occurs(A1, t),
3     post(A1, X, V1), prec(A2, X, V2), A1 != A2, V1 != V2.
```

Listing 8: Alternative Extension for $\exists$ -step plans

There are two different ways to encode the extension for $\exists$ -step plans as seen in Listing 7 and Listing 8. As before, Line 1 in Listing 7 and 8 is the same as in the sequential and $\forall$ -step encoding. To ensure that there is at least one valid permutation, either an action a_1 that invalidates the precondition of another action a_2 has to be applied after a_2 or action a_2 does not occur in this timestep. For this, all actions has to be marked as *ready* (Line 6). An action is *ready* if it either does not occur in this timestep (Line 4) or if it is captured by *apply* (Line 2). An action can be safely applied, if all other actions whose preconditions it invalidates are ready, i.e. are either applied beforehand or not occurring in this timestep. Line 6 also ensures that actions does not circularly invalidates each other.

Example 7. Running this with our example, we get three possible $\exists$ -step plans.

```

Answer: 1
occurs(getKey,1) occurs(openDoor,2) occurs(closeDoor,3) occurs(goOut,3) occurs(lightOut,3)
Answer: 2
occurs(getKey,1) occurs(openDoor,2) occurs(lightOut,2) occurs(closeDoor,3) occurs(goOut,3)
Answer: 3
occurs(lightOut,1) occurs(getKey,1) occurs(openDoor,2) occurs(closeDoor,3) occurs(goOut,3)

```

Listing 9: Output from clingo for $\exists$ -step encoding

2.2.4 encoding for relaxed $\exists$ -step plans

```

1 reach(X, V, t) :- holds(X, V, t - 1).
2 reach(X, V, t) :- occurs(A, t), apply(A, t), post(A, X, V).
3 apply(A1, t) :- action(A1), reach(X, V, t) : prec(A1, X, V);
4   ready(A2, t) : post(A1, X, V1), prec(A2, X, V2), A1 != A2 , V1 != V2.
5 ready(A, t) :- action(A), not occurs(A, t).
6 ready(A, t) :- apply(A, t).
7 :- action(A), not ready(A, t).

```

Listing 10: Extension for relaxed $\exists$ -step plans

Finally, the extension for relaxed $\exists$ -step plans as seen in Listing 10 is quite similar to the $\exists$ -step encoding. The difference between those two is that the precondition of all actions do not have to hold simultaneously but they can "help" each other out. This is done by defining the predicate `reach/3` in Line 1 and 2 as all fluents that can be reached by the step before or applied action in this timestep. An action can then be safely applied, if its precondition is reachable and as before, all actions that it invalidates are ready (Line 4). Again Line 7 ensures that applied action do not circularly invalidate each other.

Example 8. Running this with our example, we get three possible relaxed $\exists$ -step plans.

```

Answer: 1
occurs(openDoor,1) occurs(getKey,1) occurs(closeDoor,2) occurs(goOut,2) occurs(lightOut,2)
Answer: 2
occurs(openDoor,1) occurs(lightOut,1) occurs(getKey,1) occurs(closeDoor,2) occurs(goOut,2)
Answer: 3
occurs(openDoor,1) occurs(goOut,1) occurs(lightOut,1) occurs(getKey,1) occurs(closeDoor,2)

```

Listing 11: Output from clingo for relaxed $\exists$ -step encoding

2.3 Proof of Correctness

In order to prove the correctness of the presented encodings, we define the following:

- B is the rule in Line 1 of Listing 3.
- $Q(t)$ is the integrity constraint in the check program directive (Line 5) of Listing 2.
- $S(t)$ are the rules and integrity constraint in the step program directive (Lines 6-9) of Listing 2.
- $S^\square(t)$ is the extension for the specific plans, where $\square = s$ for Listing 3, $\square = \forall$ for Listing 5, $\square = \exists$ for Listing 7, and $\square = R$ for Listing 10.

For the next theorems, let I be the set of facts representing a planning task $\langle \mathcal{F}, s_0, s_*, \mathcal{O} \rangle$, $\langle a_1, \dots, a_n \rangle$ be a sequence of actions and $\langle A_1, \dots, A_m \rangle$ be a sequence of sets of actions.

Theorem 1 (Correctness of sequential plans).

$\langle a_1, \dots, a_n \rangle$ is a sequential plan iff

$$I \cup B \cup Q(0) \cup \bigcup_{t=1}^n (Q(t) \cup S(t) \cup S^s(t)) \cup \{query(n)\}.$$

has a stable model M , s.t. $\{\langle a, t \rangle \mid occurs(a, t) \in M\} = \{\langle a_t, t \rangle \mid 1 \leq t \leq n\}$.

Proof. Let $P^s(n) := I \cup B \cup Q(0) \cup \bigcup_{t=1}^n (Q(t) \cup S(t) \cup S^s(t)) \cup \{query(n)\}$.

$(\Rightarrow)$ $\langle a_1, \dots, a_n \rangle$ is a sequential plan $\Rightarrow$ any stable model M of $P^s(n)$ s.t. $\{\langle a, t \rangle \mid occurs(a, t) \in M\} = \{\langle a_t, t \rangle \mid 1 \leq t \leq n\}$ the rule in B ($holds(X, V, 0) = s_0 = (X)$), the choice rule in $S(t)$ (for given X and t , there is only one V for $holds(X, V, t)$) and both integrity constraints in $S(i)$ ($holds(X, V, t) = a^e(X)$ if $X \in dom(a^e)$, $s_{t-1}(X)$ otherwise) make sure that $holds(X, V, 0) = s_0(X)$ and $holds(X, V, t) = o(a_t, s_{t-1})(X)$, i.e.

$$\{\langle X, V, t \rangle \mid holds(X, V, t) \in M\} = \{\langle X, V, t \rangle \mid X \in \mathcal{F}, v = o(\langle a_1, \dots, a_t \rangle, s_0), 0 \leq t \leq n\}.$$

Therefore, the only stable model that $P^s(n)$ can have is

$$M = I \cup \{occurs(a_t, t) \mid 1 \leq t \leq n\} \\ \cup \{holds(X, V, t) \mid X \in \mathcal{F}, v = o(\langle a_1, \dots, a_t \rangle, s_0), 0 \leq t \leq n\} \cup \{query(n)\}.$$

s.t. $\{\langle a, t \rangle \mid occurs(a, t) \in M\} = \{\langle a_t, t \rangle \mid 1 \leq t \leq n\}$. Since all rules and integrity constraints in $P^s(n)$ are satisfied, M is a stable model of $P^s(n)$.

($\Leftarrow$) (TODO Induction) Let M be a stable model of $P^s(n)$ s.t. $\{\langle a, t \rangle \mid occurs(a, t) \in M\} = \{\langle a_t, t \rangle \mid 1 \leq t \leq n\}$. The Rule in B implies:

$$\{\langle X, V \rangle \mid holds(X, V, 0) \in M\} = \{\langle X, V \rangle \mid X \in \mathcal{F}, s_0(X) = V\}.$$

Assume that for all $1 \leq t \leq n$:

$$\{\langle X, V \rangle \mid holds(X, V, t-1) \in M\} = \{\langle X, V \rangle \mid X \in \mathcal{F}, V = o(\langle a_1, \dots, a_{t-1} \rangle, s_0)(X)\}.$$

The integrity constraint in Line 1 of Listing 3 in $S^s(t)$ ensures that the successor state, i.e. $o(a_t, o(\langle a_1, \dots, a_{t-1} \rangle, s_0))$ is defined. Additionally the choice rule in Line 6 of Listing 2 and the integrity constraints in $S(t)$ guarantee that

$$\{\langle X, V \rangle \mid holds(X, V, t) \in M\} = \{\langle X, V \rangle \mid X \in \mathcal{F}, V = o(\langle a_1, \dots, a_t \rangle, s_0)(X)\}.$$

Finally, with the fact $query(n)$, the integrity constraint in $Q(n)$ yields that $o(\langle a_1, \dots, a_n \rangle, s_0)(X) = s_*(X)$ for all $X \in dom(s_*)$. Thus, $\langle a_1, \dots, a_n \rangle$ is a sequential plan. $\square$

Theorem 2 (Correctness of parallel plans).

$\langle A_1, \dots, A_m \rangle$ is a $\forall$ -/exists-/relaxed exists--step plan iff

$$I \cup B \cup Q(0) \cup \bigcup_{t=1}^m (Q(t) \cup S(t) \cup S^p(t)) \cup \{query(m)\}$$

with $p \in \{\forall, \exists, R\}$ has a stable model M , s.t. $\{\langle a, t \rangle \mid occurs(a, t) \in M\} = \{\langle a, t \rangle \mid a \in A_t, 1 \leq t \leq m\}$.

Proof. Let $P^p(m) := I \cup B \cup Q(0) \cup \bigcup_{t=1}^m (Q(t) \cup S(t) \cup S^p(t)) \cup \{query(m)\}$ with $p \in \{\forall, \exists, R\}$. ($\Rightarrow$) $\langle A_1, \dots, A_m \rangle$ is a $\forall$ -/exists-/relaxed exists--step plan. For each $1 \leq t \leq m$, let s_t be

the state s.t. $s_t(X) = \begin{cases} a^e(X) & \forall a \in A_i \text{ and } X \in dom(a^e) \\ s_{t-1}(X) & \forall X \in \mathcal{F} \setminus \bigcup_{a \in A_i} dom(a^e) \end{cases}$. Then, as in the proof above, for any stable model M of $P^p(m)$ s.t. $\{\langle a, t \rangle \mid occurs(a, t) \in M\} = \{\langle a, t \rangle \mid a \in A_t, 1 \leq t \leq m\}$, the rule in B together with the choice rule and the integrity constraints in $S(t)$ make sure that

$$\{\langle X, V, t \rangle \mid holds(X, V, t) \in M\} = \{\langle X, V, t \rangle \mid X \in \mathcal{F}, V = s_t(X), 0 \leq t \leq m\}.$$

We now split the proof into the different cases:

Case 1: $\langle A_1, \dots, A_m \rangle$ is a $\forall$ -step plan.

The atom $single(X, t)$ is derived by the rule in $S^\forall(t)$ iff $\exists a \in A_i$ s.t. $X \in dom(a^c) \cap dom(a^e)$ and $a^c(X) \neq a^e(X)$ for $1 \leq t \leq m$. Hence $P^\forall(m)$ cannot have any stable model M apart from

$$\begin{aligned} bM = & I \cup \{occurs(a, t) \mid a \in A_t, 1 \leq t \leq m\} \\ & \cup \{holds(X, V, t) \mid X \in \mathcal{F}, V = s_t(X), 0 \leq t \leq m\} \\ & \cup \{single(X, t) \mid X \in dom(a^c) \cap dom(a^e), a^c(X) \neq a^e(X), a \in A_t, 1 \leq t \leq m\} \\ & \cup \{query(m).\} \end{aligned}$$

s.t. $\{\langle a, t \rangle \mid occurs(a, t) \in M\} = \{\langle a, t \rangle \mid a \in A_t, 1 \leq t \leq m\}$. Since for $t \in \{1, \dots, m\}$, the successor state $s_t = o(\langle a_1, \dots, a_k \rangle, s_{t-1})$ is defined for any sequence $\langle a_1, \dots, a_k \rangle$ s.t. $\{a_1, \dots, a_k\} = A_t$, we have that M satisfies all integrity constraints in $S^\forall(t)$. One can easily check that all other rules and integrity constraints in $P^\forall(m)$ are satisfied as well. Therefore M is a stable model of $P^\forall(m)$.

Case 2: $\langle A_1, \dots, A_m \rangle$ is a $\exists$ -step plan.

□

3 Method

3.1 Pipeline Overview

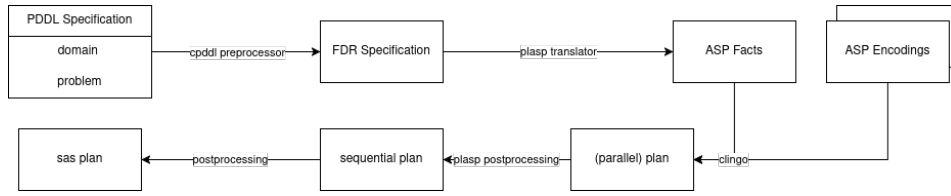


Figure 3.1: Pipeline for testing the different planning encodings

To test and compare the different parallel planning encodings against each other and against the sequential planning encoding, we set up a python pipeline using the lab framework (Seipp et al. 2017) and the unofficial collection of (sequential) IPC benchmark instances from the downward project ¹.

Starting at a planning task in the Planning Domain Definition Language (PDDL), we first preprocess it using cpddl (Fišer 2025) that converts it into a finite domain representation (FDR). Plasp then takes the FDR as input and translates it into ASP facts representing the planning task. Further information of this step can be found in (DIMOPOULOS et al. 2019). Using clingo with a modified version of the incremental encodings presented above together with the facts from the output of plasp, we can then compute sequential, $\forall$ -step, $\exists$ -step or relaxed $\exists$ -step plans as stable models. Finally, to validate the given plan, we postprocess the parallel representation back into a sequential plan, using the postprocess encoding provided by plasp and validate the plan with VAL ². Each step has some optimizations and configurations that will be explained in the following sections.

3.2 Optimizations

3.2.1 Mutexes

Definition 7 *mutex and mutex groups*. A set of facts $M \subseteq \mathcal{F}$ is called

- (i) a *mutex* $\iff$ for all reachable states $s : M \not\subseteq s$.

¹<https://github.com/aibasel/downward-benchmarks>

²<https://github.com/KCL-Planning/VAL>

(ii) a *mutex group* $:\iff$ for all reachable states $s : |M \cap s| \leq 1$.

In other words, a mutex is a set of fluents that can never be true at the same time in any reachable state, while a mutex group is a set of fluents where at most one fluent can be true at the same time. Mutexes and mutex groups can be used to optimize the planning encodings by reducing the search space. For this, we extend our encoding in Listing 2 with the following rules:

```

1      #program base.
2      ...
3      mutex(G,X) :- mutexGroup(G), contains(G,X,V), fluent(X,V).
4      mutex(G)   :- mutexGroup(G), #count{X : mutex(G,X)} > 1.
5      :- mutex(G), #count{X,V : holds(X,V,0), contains(G,X,V)} > 1.
6      ...
7      #program step(t).
8      ...
9      :- mutex(G), #count{X,V : holds(X,V,t), contains(G,X,V)} > 1.
10     ...

```

Listing 12: Expansion for mutexes

Here, the mutex group G is given by plasp as facts of the form *mutexGroup*/1 and *contains*/3. In the base program, we first define which fluents belong to a mutex group (Line 3), where a group must contain at least two fluents (Line 4). The integrity constraint in Line 5 ensures that no more than one fluent of each mutex group holds in the initial state and the integrity constraint in Line 9 ensures the same for each state in timestep t .

3.2.2 Guess and Check

An optimization specific to the (relaxed) $\exists$ -step encodings is the guess and check approach. The general idea is to first guess a solution without looking for actions that circularly invalidate each other and afterwards check if the guessed solution has a cycle. Formally, we encode the problem by a pair of programs $\langle G, C \rangle$ where G is the guessing program and C is the checking program. Stable models M of G yields a solution if $C \cap M$ is *unsatisfiable*. For making "systematic" guesses, (DIMOPOULOS et al. 2019) proposes to use the core program ($S(t)$) in Listing 2 together with the integrity constraint in Line 1 of Listing 3, 5 or 7 (B) and the facts representing a planning task. Thus, a stable model M of G is s.t. the pre- and postconditions hold for all actions applied in parallel (Line 8 of Listing 2 and Line 1 of Listing 3, 5 or 7). and the integrity constraint in Line 8 of Listing 2 also ensures confluence of applied actions. The only thing

remained to be checked is if actions circularly invalidate each other, i.e. $a^e(X) \neq \tilde{a}^e(X)$ and $\tilde{a}^e(\tilde{X}) \neq \tilde{a}^e(\tilde{X})$. This can be accomplished by taking the atoms over $occurs/2$ from M as facts together with a program C containing the facts representing a planning task and the following encoding:

```

1  #include <incmode>.
2  #program check(t).
3  :- query(t), not cycle(t).
4  #program step(t).
5  prec(A, X, V, t) :- prec(A, X, V), occurs(A, t).
6  post(A, X, V, t) :- post(A, X, V), occurs(A, t).
7  action(A, t) :- occurs(A, t).
8  apply(A1, t) :- action(A1, t),
9      ready(A2, t) :- post(A1, X, V1, t), prec(A2, X, V2, t), A1 != A2 , V1 != V2.
10 ready(A, t) :- action(A, t), not occurs (A, t).
11 ready (A, t) :- apply(A, t).
12 cycle(t) :- action (A, t), not ready (A, t).

```

Listing 13: Encoding for checking circular invalidation

Here, the maximum value for t in subprogram *check* and *step* is $m = \max\{t \mid occurs(a, t)\}$ and C becomes *unsatisfiable* if $t > m$. Like in Listing 7, we check for each t if all actions $A \in occurs(A, t)$ can be applied by the predicate *ready* (Line 7-11). If actions in A circularly invalidate each other, *ready*(A, t) is underivable for these actions and thus *cycle*(t) (Line 12) in step t is derived. Hence, C becomes satisfiable if there is a circular invalidation in step t , which means that there is no permutation of the actions A , s.t. the successor state is defined and therefore not (relaxed) $\exists$ -step serializable.

3.2.3 Heuristic

Clingo backward heuristic

3.3 Experiment

Setup + Configs

4 Results

4.1 One to One Comparison

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